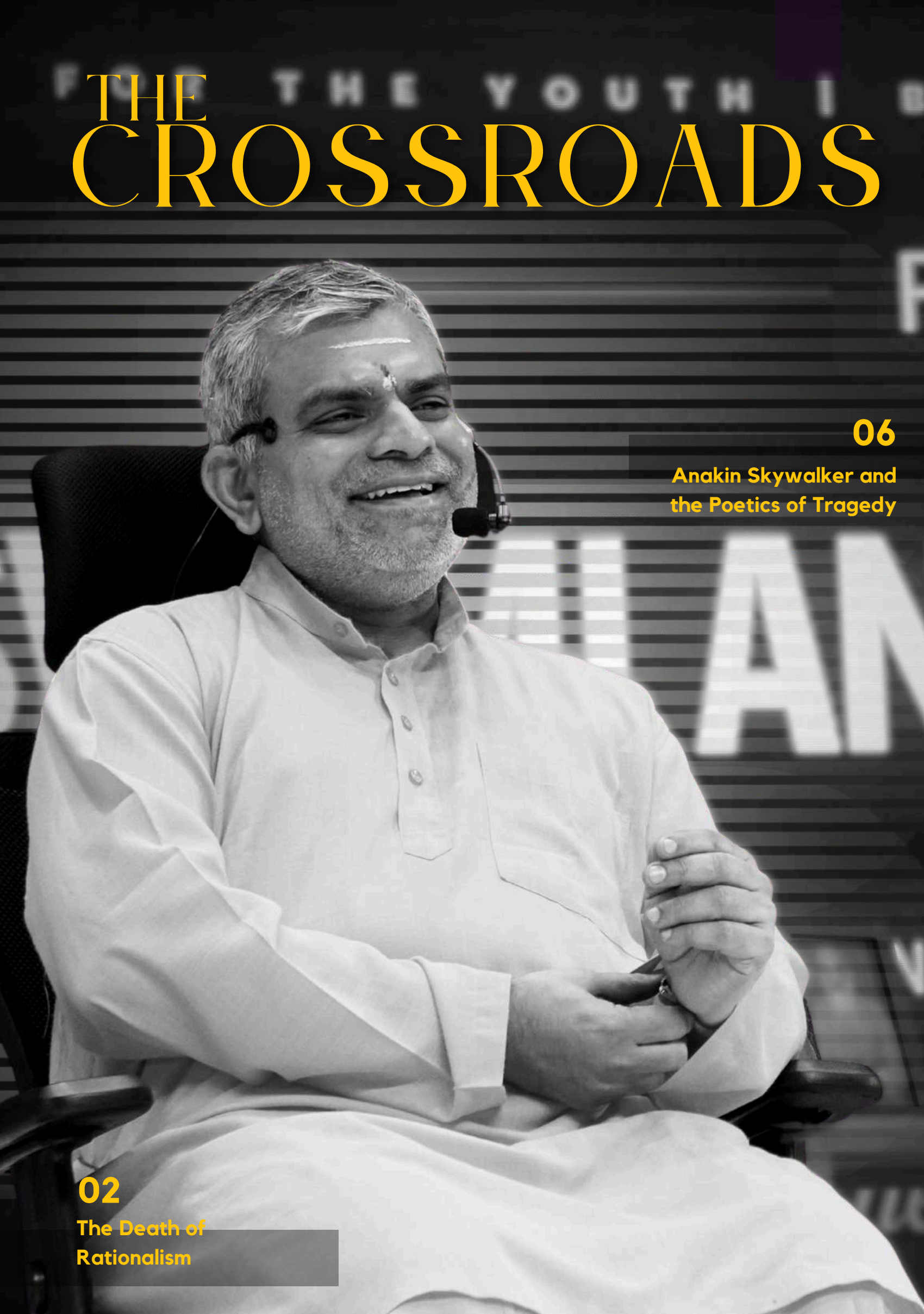


THE CROSSROADS



06

Anakin Skywalker and
the Poetics of Tragedy

02

The Death of
Rationalism

Contents

Independence Day Issue



Features

03 The Death of Rationalism

Rationalism is often seen as a virtue. But what happens when it becomes an identity rather than a method of understanding. Explore how when preventing you from questioning it, the very principle of objective rationalism gets eradicated.

02 Crossbusters

A curated selection of books and movies, tailored just for Independence day. Immerse yourself in Bharatiya culture, pride and history!

04 What Lies Beyond the Anthem

An article on the dichotomy of nationalism, Highlighting both its successes and troubles, especially in the context of our intricate history.

06 Anakin Skywalker and the Poetics of Tragedy

Star Wars is often dismissed as mere pulp fiction. But underneath the "sci-fi" lies a tragedy comparable to Shakespeare's works. A deeply intellectual analysis guided by the 4 Aristotelian categories, this article offers something truly insightful.

05 Beyond the Lobby

Online games are often seen as a vice. Disproving this belief, the article explores the many - unknown - benefits of one of the most popular games - Call Of Duty (mobile version!).

08 Tilka Manjhi

Fitting for an Independence day issue, the article talks about one of the most overlooked patriots in our history. Follow the life of this lionheart who fought British Raj

01 The Editorial

07 CVP Reflection

The Devil 09 Wears A Price Tag

10 Jargon

11 The Way Back



THE EDITORIAL

Listening to old speeches recorded on the radio and shot through with static awaken emotions I have never felt before. Reading old poetry from damp, yellow pages bring tears to our eyes despite being completely distanced from our lives. Why do these seemingly ancient works of art continue to be some of the most beautiful works of art? Why do we still refer to the art of the past to inspire ourselves?

It is not that we have no talent. It is the fact that we have no purpose. We have no fire in our heart that makes it necessary for us to produce works that create meaningful change. Rabindranath Tagore's poetry was inspired by the necessity of creating national fervor, pride for the nation, and love for the motherland. Subramania Bharati's verses were born of the need for mobilization in Southern Bharat.

Now, 79 years later, does no student have any purpose? Do we have no reason to write, to paint, to inspire? Bharat has a long way to go; to bring back its education, its art, its values. While there is so much yet to achieve, how can we not believe that we have a purpose? That we do not have something toward which to concentrate our effort? We must use what we have, our hands, our minds, our creativity. Our art is not simply beautiful; you take away everything it can be by simply appreciating beauty. We must use every tool at our disposal to build the Bharat of the future, and our art is one of our best. Work with only Bharat in your hearts, to improve, improve, improve!

Beginning in the early 1900s, and still in use today, art has always been required to create true change. Take one of the most recent examples of upheaval: Independence. However much we attempt to protest that it was protest or force that finally ejected the British from India like the virus they were, art has always been at the foreground. Whether it was the product of a brush's flourish, the scratching of ink into paper, or the voices that mesmerized us, the period produced works that will be nearly impossible for any warm-blooded human to forget. Why is it so difficult for students like us to find this beauty within ourselves? Why is it that whenever we put pens to paper, what is produced is mass-production quality, flimsy and insignificant?

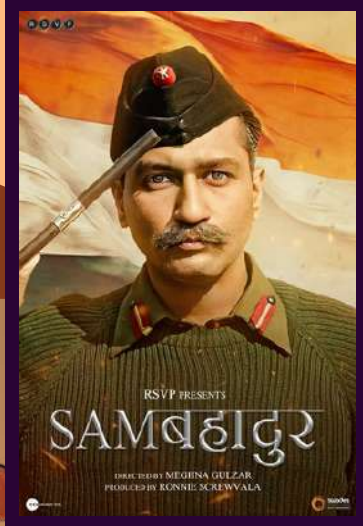
AWAKE! ARISE! AND STOP NOT

TILL THE WORK IS DONE

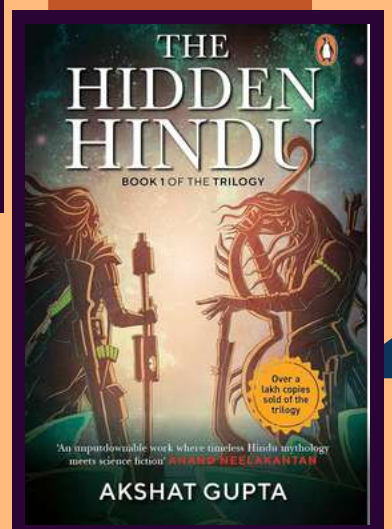
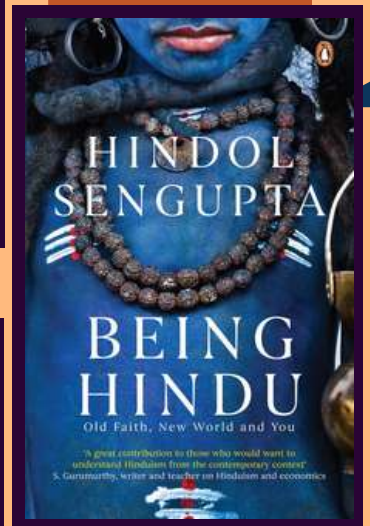
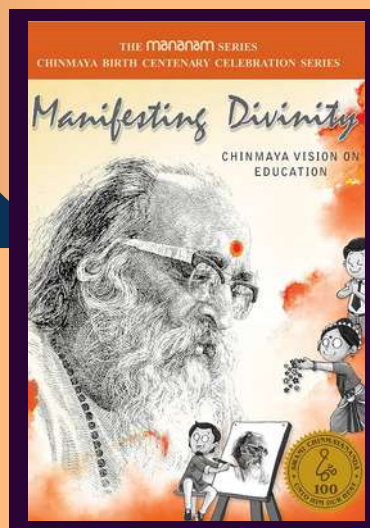
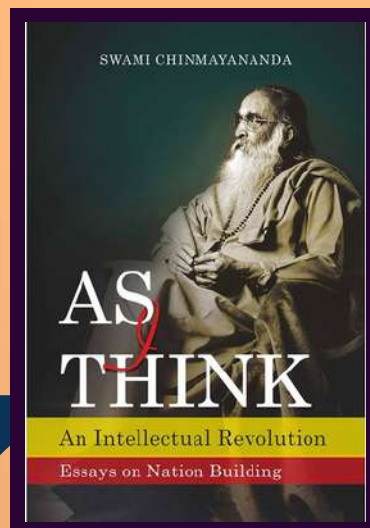


CROSS BUSTERS

MOVIES



BOOKS



The *Death* Of Rationalism

Rationalism was meant to be a method, not an identity. It was to be the discipline of honest seeing, not another tribe of the like-minded. You question, you examine, you see clearly. You hold no belief sacred, no authority exempt – including your own. Every conclusion must justify itself and if it cannot, you let it go. That is the original promise. From the Greek sceptics to the Enlightenment philosophers to the modern scientific temper, this is what rationalism has always claimed as its essence: the courage to ask, the willingness to discard, the refusal to bow before any idea simply because it is old or revered or comfortable.

The courage to question rather than blindly obey, to examine rather than merely accept: this is what allows the mind to mature and society to remain free.

None of this is an argument against rationalism as a method. The method works. Peer review catches errors, replication weeds out fraud, falsification disciplines speculation. The institution of science corrects what the individual scientist cannot. But the method's virtue does not automatically transfer to the practitioner. A system can be self-correcting while the people within it remain thoroughly self-deceived. It is this gap, between what rationalism promises and what the rationalist practices, that concerns us here.

The Outward Gaze

Watch the rationalist in action. He will tell you precisely why the pilgrim is wasting his time at the temple, but he cannot tell you why he himself spent three hours last night arguing with strangers on the internet. He will explain the cognitive biases that make people believe in astrology, yet he has never once examined the compulsion that makes him need to correct them. He writes essays on why people cling to tradition. Still, he cannot see that his own identity as “the one who sees through tradition” is just as clung to, just as defended, just as psychologically necessary to him as any ritual is to a devotee.

This is the fatal flaw. Reason directed only outward is not complete reason; it is half-reason, and half-reason is often more dangerous than no reason at all because it comes with the illusion of completeness.

The religious believer at least knows he believes. The rationalist who has made reason into identity does not know he believes; he thinks he merely sees. And so his beliefs operate unchecked, unexamined, all the more powerful for being invisible. Belief in reason is something else entirely. It is reason frozen into dogma, producing certainty rather than clarity, positions rather than understanding, debates rather than insight. The believer in reason has made rationality into a flag, and he will defend that flag as fiercely as any religious zealot defends his scripture. His positions are not held because they are true but because they are his; his arguments are not aimed at understanding but at victory. His rationalism has become, in everything but name, a faith.



Rationalism without self-enquiry cannot see its own motivations. Fear, insecurity, superiority, the need to be right – these operate freely beneath the language of logic. The rationalist believes he is defending truth, but he does not see that he is defending himself. He believes he is exposing others' irrationality, but he does not see the irrationality of his own emotional investment in being the one who exposes.

Reason is then used to justify psychological compulsions rather than dissolve them. The ego learns to speak in syllogisms; it marshals data the way a lawyer marshals precedents, not to find truth but to win the case. And the case is always the same: I am right, I am rational, I am superior to those who are not.

In certain Western rationalist circles, approved conclusions function as membership tests. Deviate, even carefully and with evidence, and you are not refuted but reclassified: you become a denialist, a bigot, someone who has “revealed their true colors.” The argument is not answered; the arguer is diagnosed. Among several Indian rationalists, the pattern mirrors. One must hold the correct contempt for all religion and the “correct” suspicion of all tradition. Suggest that an ancient text contains genuine philosophical insight, and you risk being treated as a communal apologist; question whether one particular civilizational model is the only path to human flourishing, and you become intellectually untouchable. In both cases, the permitted conclusions are known in advance, and argument no longer exists to discover truth but to police boundaries. This is not reason at work; it is the ego defending its shelter, now speaking the language of rationality.

Try it now. Pick a position you hold dear, one you have defended publicly, one that feels obviously correct. Ask: what do I get from holding this? Not what is true about it, but what does it give me? Watch what arises. If the mind rushes to justify the position, that rush is the answer. If irritation arises at the question itself, that irritation is the answer. Self-enquiry does not require you to abandon your conclusions; it only asks you to see who is clinging to them, and why.



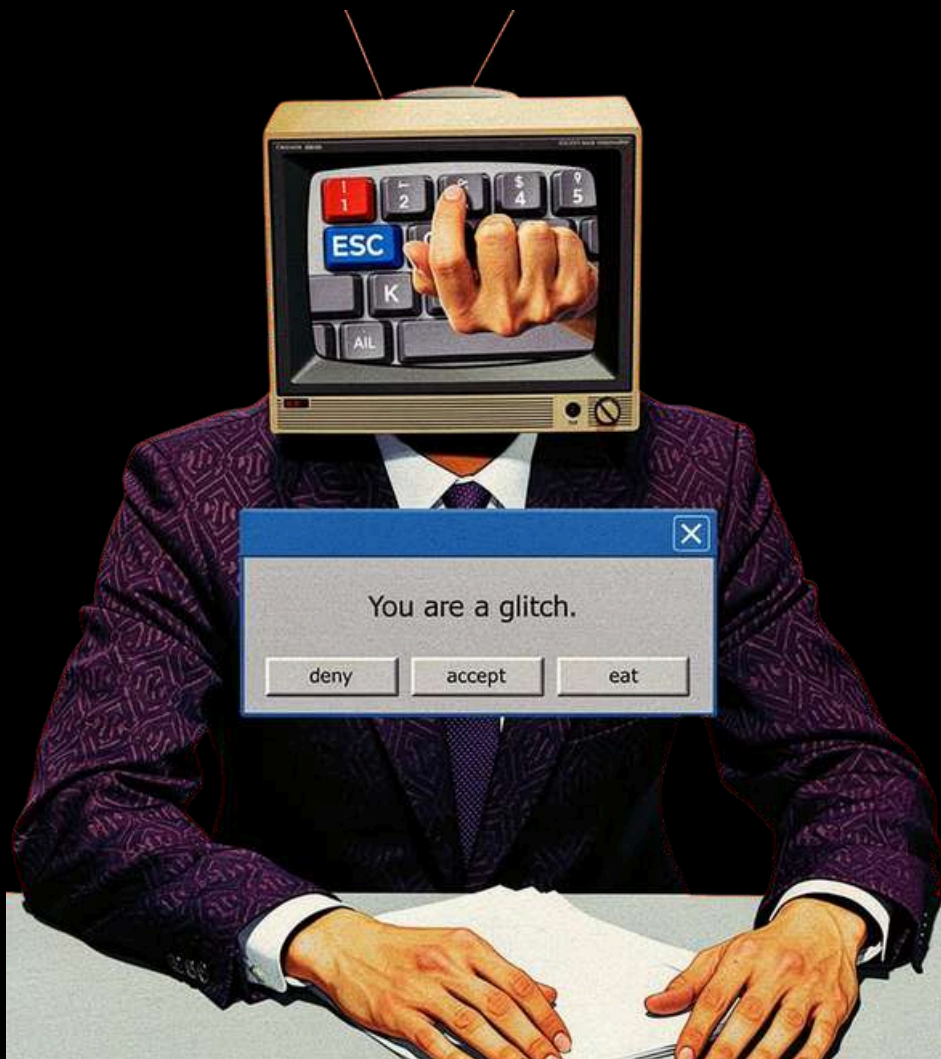
This is the questioning the ego cannot survive. It can survive any external argument; it can change positions, update beliefs, switch tribes, and remain fundamentally intact. What it cannot survive is being seen.

This is why self-enquiry is so rare, and why it is so essential. The rationalist who has never asked, “What am I really doing when I argue?”, who has never noticed the pleasure in being right, the fear of being wrong, the satisfaction of superiority, has never used reason fully. He has used reason the way a child uses a stick: to hit things, defend territory, feel powerful. He has not yet used reason the way a surgeon uses a scalpel: to cut through illusion, beginning with his own.

The bars are elegant, the locks are logical, and the prisoner is convinced he is free because he can critique the cages of others. But he remains inside, for he has never questioned the one who built the cage, who maintains the cage, who is terrified of life outside the cage. His cage has a sign on it that says “No Cage,” and he believes the sign.

Liberation is not a change of content; it is freedom from the need to cling to any content. The liberated mind can hold positions without being held by them, can use reason without being used by the ego's need for reason, can think without needing thought to tell it who it is.

This liberation is not achieved by abandoning rationalism; it is achieved by completing it, by turning the light that has illuminated so much of the external world, finally, uncompromisingly, on the one who holds the light.



This liberation is not achieved by abandoning rationalism; it is achieved by completing it, by turning the light that has illuminated so much of the external world, finally, uncompromisingly, on the one who holds the light.

The question is not whether you can question religion, tradition, politics, or superstition; you have already demonstrated that capacity. The question is whether you can question the questioner. Can you ask, with genuine not-knowing: What am I defending? What am I afraid of? Who would I be if I could no longer call myself rational?

Begin there. That is the only beginning worth the name. Refuse, and you remain what you have always been: an ego armed with arguments, a prisoner who has memorised every book on liberation but never bothered to look at his own chains.

INTRODUCING...

When the youth begin to have ideas, they are fueled to unimaginable heights, blazing paths for the world to follow. Yuva Samvad provides a platform for the bold young minds of CIRS to bring their ideas out into the world. It encourages a deeper reflection for the student speakers beyond surface-level ideas. Gurudev had a vision for youth who think for themselves and start conversations worth having.

Youth Alone Can

WHAT LIES BEYOND THE ANTHEM

- CHINMAY KANODIA | XI MGMT

On August 15th, India—from Kashmir to Kanyakumari, Gujarat to Arunachal Pradesh—lights up in a united celebration. Throughout the day, across the nation, the national anthem resounds for fifty-two seconds.

What awakens during those fifty-two seconds is nationalism—a word that today inspires both praise and critique in equal measure. Originally, it meant “self-governance for a people bound by shared history and land”. The Indian National Congress, founded in 1885, was built on this ideal. By 1930, when Mahatma Gandhi marched to Dandi against the salt tax, this vision had captured thousands, with many even willing to face imprisonment for it. India exists today because ordinary people held fast to this belief: empires rarely fall apart otherwise.

Yet nationalism has also brought immense harm. The British Empire, which India resisted, was driven by a similar ideology—one that fueled the oppression of millions globally. Around the same time, Germany and Japan expanded their empires on these very grounds.

This leads us to view nationalism as a force rather than a virtue. Its impact depends entirely on who directs it and to what end. Rabindranath Tagore warned us of these dangers during the freedom struggle. In 1916 and 1917, he cautioned that a nation worshipping itself risks becoming the very empire it fights. Never afraid to speak truth even to the powerful, Tagore renounced his knighthood in 1919 following the Jallianwala Bagh massacre.

He sought an independent India, but believed nationalism demanded constant vigilance. Many freedom fighters shared this view, criticizing India more fiercely than any outsider to push for internal reform.

This spirit lived in BR Ambedkar’s *Annihilation of Caste*, a scathing critique of Indian society, and in Gandhi’s frequent anger with his followers. We honor them as patriots, even though much of their legacy was relentless nation-criticism.

The Constitution they helped write remains incomplete. Education for all children between six and fourteen became a right only in 2002, with the law to enforce it passed seven years later. Pointing out these gaps is not disloyal, it is a necessary step towards making the nation better.

What, then, does the national anthem truly ask of us on August 15th? Far less than grand speeches suggest, and far less glamorous. The dusty road outside the school gate is as much the country as any ideal. There are twenty-one other scheduled languages to learn, though quiet efforts rarely draw applause. Freedom was forged through hard, uncertain work by people who lacked any guarantee of success.

सत्यमेव जयतेनानृतम् सत्येन पन्था विततो देवयानः

satyameva jayate nānṛtaṃ, satyena panthā vitato devayānaḥ

Seventy-nine years is not as long as it seems; there are still people who live to tell the tales of 1947 India. Our country is still progressing, growing, and improving. And what the national anthem truly means is decided by what people do on the other 364 days of the year.

B E Y O N D T H E L O B B Y

MUHIL T. | IB I YR

A digital world where millions come together- some for a living, some for leisure, some for addiction, and some for peace. Deafening gunshots and unpredictable maps: the battleground isn't only found in massive PlayStation consoles or an expensive PC rig—it's compressed into the palm of your hand, radiating heat, chaos, and adrenaline. Welcome to *Call of Duty: Mobile*. In a game where victory is decided in milliseconds, strategy isn't the only thing that backs you: it's the agile human reflexes that do their magic. Every player has his own custom layout and style of gameplay, be it rushing to the enemy's base in multiplayer, camping with a sniper in a hidden spot, or splitting within the squad in Battle Royale to avoid team wipeouts. A professional gamer spends at least 6-10 hours a day pushing his rank and stacking victories. Older generations love to warn us that gaming is just a mindless, addictive distraction, but fast-paced games like

Call of Duty: Mobile actually give your brain a serious workout. Constantly scanning small screens for tiny movements sharpens your spatial awareness and forces your mind to process information much faster than it normally would. A missed glare from a sniper's scope can cost a match. Overlooking a fighter jet nearby can kill the entire squad. Neuroscience proves this isn't just theory: In a landmark tracking test, action gamers completely outperformed non-gamers in hand-eye coordination, scoring an average of **293 compared to just 162**—marking a near **55% reduction in precision errors**. Adding to this, a University of Toronto study confirmed that playing fast-paced shooters like *Call of Duty* explicitly rewires the brain to absorb and master new real-world sensorimotor tasks drastically faster than the

general population. Every tap of the finger is coordinated, and even the shadows are not left unseen. Gamers are known for their superhuman reflexes. But these sharp reflexes and rewired neural pathways are just the basic physical entry requirements. The true value of this modern playground isn't measured in milliseconds or high scores; rather, it's about how it helps us grow, connect, and bounce back. When a player logs in, they aren't just escaping reality; they are entering an arena that demands immediate collaboration, emotional regulation under constant pressure, and a culture of constancy where failure is never a final defeat but a lesson. In a world that often isolates us, gaming has quietly become a shared community where global friendships are built.



ANAKIN SKYWALKER

and THE POETICS of TRAGEDY

AAYUSH S. B. |
IB II YR

The Star Wars prequel is, at its core, a tragedy. Yet within popular discourse it has long been dismissed as pulp science fiction; a spectacle over substance sort of material. This article resists that dismissal. It reads *Star Wars Episode III: Revenge of the Sith* (2005), contrary to popular claim, not as blockbuster cinema, but as a literary text, and subjects its dialogue to the same scrutiny one might apply to Sophocles or Shakespeare. The central claim lies in this: The dialogue in *Revenge of the Sith* (both Anakin's own speech and the exchanges constructed around him) functions as a deliberate literary mechanism that builds him into a recognizable tragic hero, one whose contours are shaped by the conventions Aristotle delineated in the *Poetics* and which recur across the tragic canon from Oedipus to Macbeth.

The analysis is mainly modelled around four Aristotelian categories: *Hamartia* (The fatal flaw that initiates the flaw), *Peripeteia* (the reversal of fortune), *Anagnorisis* (the moment of recognition), and the cathartic effect produced in the audience through *Eleos* and *Phobos* (pity and fear).

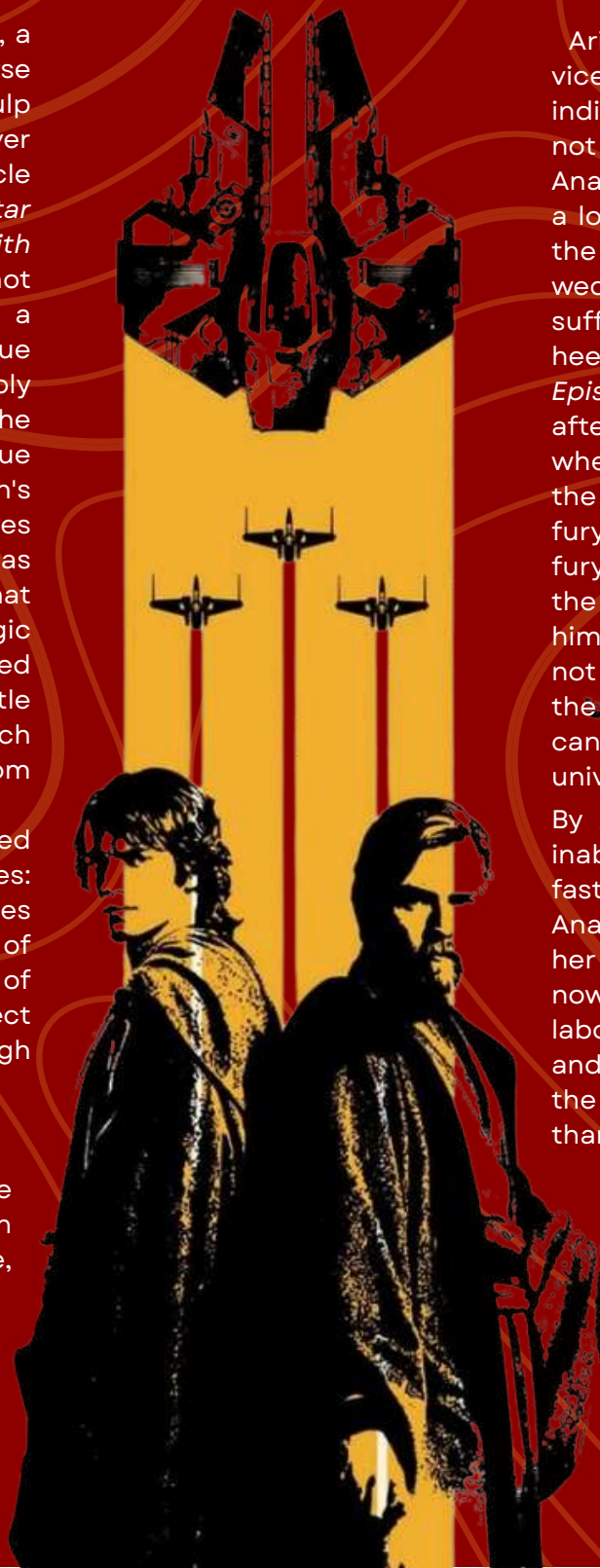
Hamartia - The Tyranny of Devotion

Aristotle's *Hamartia* works not as vice but as frailty, an imperfection indigenous to the hero's own nature, a not imposed on him from without. In Anakin, this frailty takes the shape of love so absolute it cannot tolerate the ordinary erosions of mortality, wedded to a conviction that sufficient will can bend even fate to heel.

Aristotle's *Hamartia* works not as vice but as frailty, an imperfection indigenous to the hero's own nature, not imposed on him from without. In Anakin, this frailty takes the shape of a love so absolute it cannot tolerate the ordinary erosions of mortality, wedded to a conviction that sufficient will can bend even fate to heel. The seed of this flaw is sown in *Episode II: Attack of the Clones*, in the aftermath of his mother's death, when he confesses the massacre of the Tusken Raiders to Padmé, with fury, rather than grief or regret. This fury resolves into 3 words that indict the greater picture rather than himself, or the cosmos, if I may: "it's not fair." Here, in embryonic form is the tragedy entirely: a boy who cannot reconcile himself to a universe indifferent to his longing.

By *Revenge of The Sith*, this same inability of reconciliation has fastened itself to Padmé. When Anakin confesses that he has seen her death, "As clearly as I see you now", the line performs a double labor, it renders his devotion total, and it exposes his relationship with the future as one of conquest rather than surrender.

A Jedi is schooled in relinquishment, Anakin has never once relinquished anything, and his vow that he "won't let this one become true" is possession disguised in the vocabulary of love.



*Peripeteia - The Reversal
Born of the Self*

Aristotle held that the most devastating reversals are those the hero unknowingly manufactures himself. Anakin's Peripeteia arrives in the Chancellor's chambers, where he enters believing himself the exposé of treachery and departs its instrument. His plea to Mace Windu that Palpatine be tried, not executed, is in itself the hamartia made manifest in its purest form: the same desperate insistence that the universe yield to his terms rather than its own. In striking down Windu, Anakin does not so much fall as continue, the gesture is not what most believe as rupture, but culmination, the tragic logic in which catastrophe emerges organically from character rather than intruding upon it. Every act that follows, the kneeling before his new master, the extinguishing of the Temple, unfolds with the merciless coherence tragedy demands, that which being, inevitability legible only in retrospect.

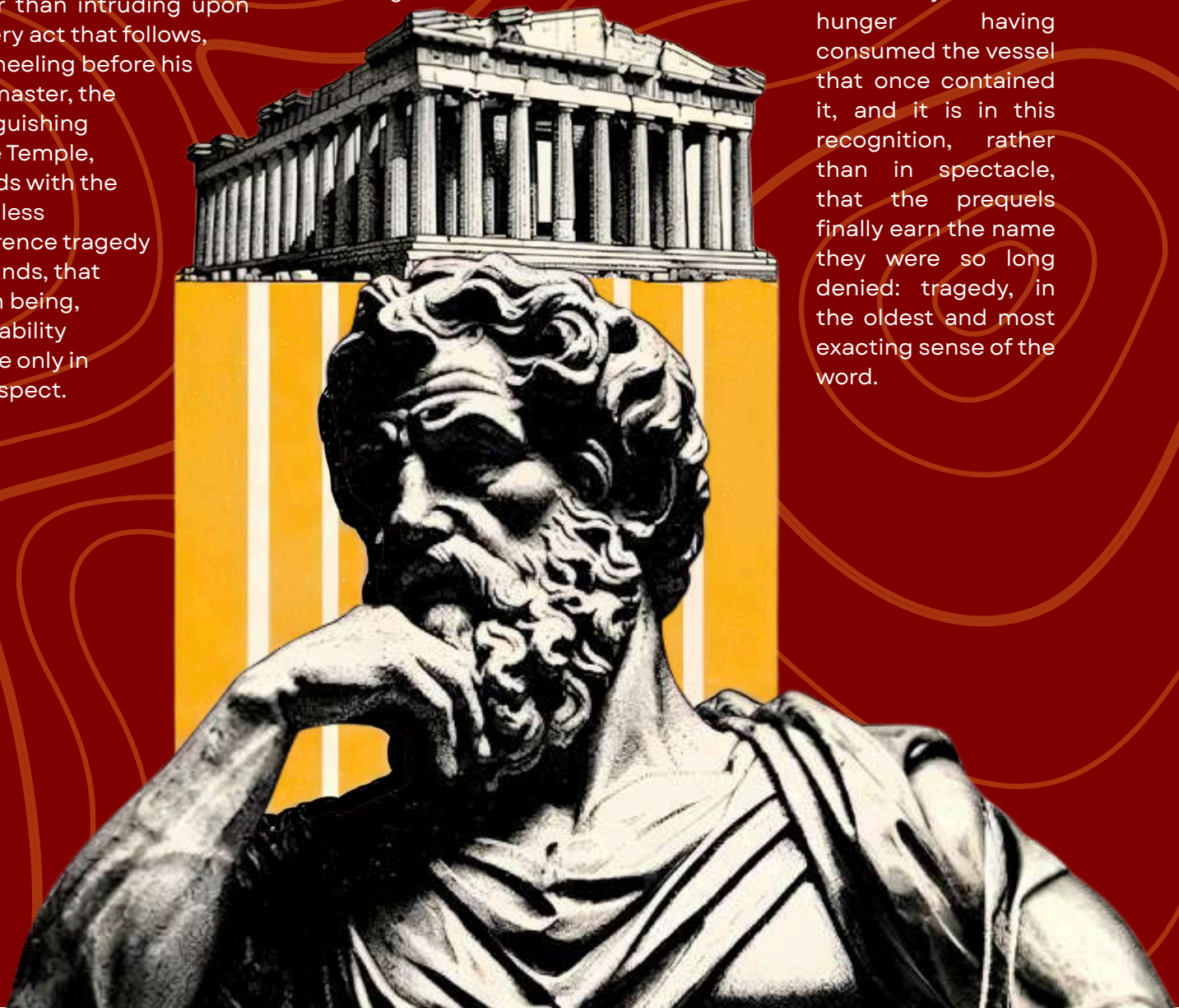
*Anagnorisis - The Ash of
Understanding*

Anakin's anagnorisis arrives as nothing but ash. On Mustafar, confronted by Padmé's horror, he answers with the knife of accusation, rather than clarity. Obi-Wan, he insists, has turned her against him, a sentence that reveals the absolute absence of knowledge, a man narrating his ruin as persecution. True recognition is delayed until he lies mutilated upon the volcanic shore, his voice dissolving into a scream directed at the man who defeated him. This too yet fails as wisdom, barely at its threshold, the first dim apprehension of an irony too exquisite to be coincidence: the vision he tortured himself to avert, he alone brought into being.

*Catharsis: The Terror
of Recognition*

Aristotle believed tragedy should leave its witness trembling with Eleos and Phobos in equal measure; pity for the one who falls, and dread at the narrowness of the distance between his fall and one's own. It is this second current that popular memory has long declined to feel, for Anakin's flaw is neither exotic nor alien; it is love disfigured by the fear of its own impermanence, the seductive and universal delusion that longing, sufficiently fierce, might compel the world into submission. Few who have felt this impulse become Vader. But the mechanical exhalation that closes the film, supplanting forever the voice that carried three pictures, is not the sound of a monster's birth. It is the sound of an entirely human

hunger having consumed the vessel that once contained it, and it is in this recognition, rather than in spectacle, that the prequels finally earn the name they were so long denied: tragedy, in the oldest and most exacting sense of the word.



CVP REFLECTION

| SMT. SHILPA NITHYANAND |

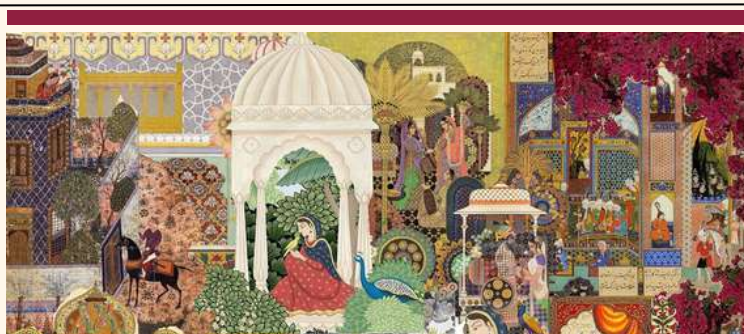


The Orientation Program for New Teachers at Chinmaya Gardens, Coimbatore (28.07.'26 - 31.07. '26) opened doors to Pujya Gurudev Swami Cinmayananda ji's four-fold daily spiritual practice for self reflection and introspection. Entering it, I expected it to be another professional development programme to enhance my teaching skills. However, I realised that CVP was not merely about becoming a better teacher—it was about becoming a better human being and responsible educator. The thoughtfully designed itinerary, covering intellectual, spiritual, physical and mental development, Indian culture, patriotism, technology, teaching practices and a universal outlook, made the experience extremely holistic.

One of the most significant aspects of the programme was its emphasis on this holistic development. The sessions on Mental Development, Physical Development and Spiritual Development reminded me that education must address the whole personality. As teachers, we often concentrate on academic achievement and examination results. CVP made me pause and reflect on the emotional, physical and spiritual well-being of both teachers and students. I realised that a calm, balanced and emotionally healthy teacher can create a much more positive classroom environment. I would like to incorporate reflection, meaningful conversations and activities that encourage emotional well-being in my classroom.



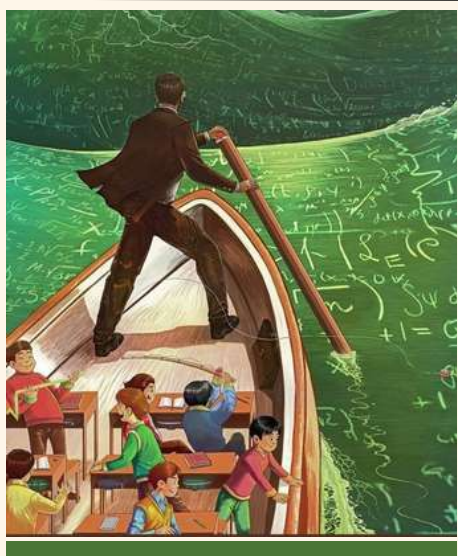
The programme began with flag hoisting, inauguration and an overview of the programme, which set the right tone for the days ahead. The introduction to CVP helped me understand that education is broader than the transmission of knowledge. A teacher has the responsibility of shaping minds, nurturing values and inspiring young people to become compassionate and responsible citizens. The ice-breaking sessions created an atmosphere of openness and camaraderie. They helped teachers from different parts of India interact freely and discover common experiences despite coming from different schools and backgrounds.



The sessions on Indian Culture and Patriotism were thought-provoking. They reminded me that education must help students understand and appreciate the richness of our heritage while also preparing them to participate responsibly in the modern world. Patriotism, I realised, is not merely about ceremonies; it can be expressed through honesty, responsibility, respect and sincere contribution to society. As an English teacher, I would like to bring more Indian contexts, stories, values and contemporary issues into my lessons so that students can connect what they learn with their own cultural and social environment.



The sessions on Intellectual Development and Universal Outlook broadened my understanding of education. Intellectual growth should encourage curiosity, questioning, critical thinking and the ability to see different perspectives. A universal outlook encourages us to rise above narrow boundaries and appreciate people, cultures and ideas different from our own. This was particularly meaningful because the participants themselves represented the diversity of India. Interacting with teachers from different states gave me an opportunity to listen to different educational experiences, teaching practices and perspectives. It made me realise that although our classrooms may differ, our fundamental purpose remains the same—to make a positive difference in the lives of our students.



The demonstration classes in Mathematics and English were especially useful from a professional perspective. Observing another teacher conduct a lesson provided valuable insights into classroom transaction, presentation, questioning, student engagement and lesson planning. The session on Lesson Plan further reinforced the importance of planning with a clear purpose. I learnt that a good lesson plan should not simply list activities; it should connect learning objectives, pedagogy, student participation, assessment and real-life application. I intend to revisit my own lesson plans and make them more learner-centred, interactive and experiential.



The sessions on “Know How – Exploring the Ways of Learning” and Technology and Teaching were particularly relevant to the changing educational landscape. Technology can make learning interactive and engaging, but it should remain a means rather than an end. I intend to use technology purposefully—to encourage collaboration, creativity, research, presentation and independent learning rather than simply making lessons visually attractive. I also want to provide students opportunities to think, question, solve problems and apply knowledge to real-life situations.



My pride in visiting my CIRS and enlightening other teachers on its journey was another memorable part of the programme. We were seeing an educational institution in action - how vision, values, infrastructure and pedagogy can create a meaningful learning environment. The session on “All About the Founder” helped me appreciate how an educational vision can grow into an enduring institution when it is supported by commitment, perseverance and a clear sense of purpose.

Beyond the formal sessions, one of the greatest takeaways was the human connection I experienced. Meeting teachers from different parts of India was an experience in itself. We came from different linguistic, cultural and professional backgrounds, yet we laughed together, learned together, shared experiences and supported one another. These interactions reminded me of India's diversity and the common bond connecting educators across geographical boundaries. The friendships and professional connections I formed are something I hope to carry forward.

As I return to my classroom, I do not want the learning from CVP to remain confined to the programme. I want to carry its principles into my everyday life—greater self-awareness, continuous learning, compassion, discipline, openness, patriotism, technological adaptability and a universal outlook. I choose to become a teacher who not only teaches English but also inspires students to think, feel, question, respect and grow.

The CVP experience has therefore become much more than a professional training programme for me. It has given me an opportunity to reflect on who I am as a teacher and who I aspire to become. It has encouraged me to look at teaching not simply as a profession but as a responsibility and a lifelong journey of learning.

I believe that the lessons of CVP will remain with me long after the programme has ended. Teaching methods may change, technology may evolve and educational expectations may continue to grow, but the values of compassion, balance, discipline, openness and continuous learning will always remain relevant. CVP is not just a session that I attended; it is a journey that I have begun—a journey towards becoming a more balanced teacher, a better human being and a lifelong learner.



TILKA MANJHI

Long before the Revolt of 1857 had taken place by the sepoys and other Indian rulers... Long before the word “freedom struggle” had even entered the Indian subcontinent... A young boy in the foothills of Bihar had already picked up his bow and challenged the rule of the British East India Company. The name of this boy was Tilka Manjhi, and his is a story of raw courage, pain and sacrifice for his people and his community.

Originally named Jabra Pahadia, Tilka Manjhi was born to a tribal Santhali family on February the 11th 1950 in a small village called Tilakpur near Sultanganj in Bihar. From a young age, Jabra watched the British tighten their grip on the hills and forests of the Paharia and Santhal tribes where his people had been living for generations. The British East India Company had seized their forest land, imposed heavy taxes on the meagre amount of leftover land and treated them like trespassers on their own property. Even the village elderly and children were humiliated and insulted about their tribal practices and traditions and their inability to pay the imposed taxes on them. Watching his community lose their dignity in their own land, Jabra hardened his resolve, he could not simply watch his people suffer.

This resolve led him to become the “Manjhi” - the headman of his village. It was at this time when the British were calling him ‘Tilka’ - a person who is fierce and courageous. Between 1771 and 1784, Tilka strived to unite the scattered tribal communities living in the forests in the Rajmahal hills of Bihar. Tilka had trained his people in guerilla warfare and other weaponry techniques, empowering his people.

KSVN VISWANTH | IB I YEAR



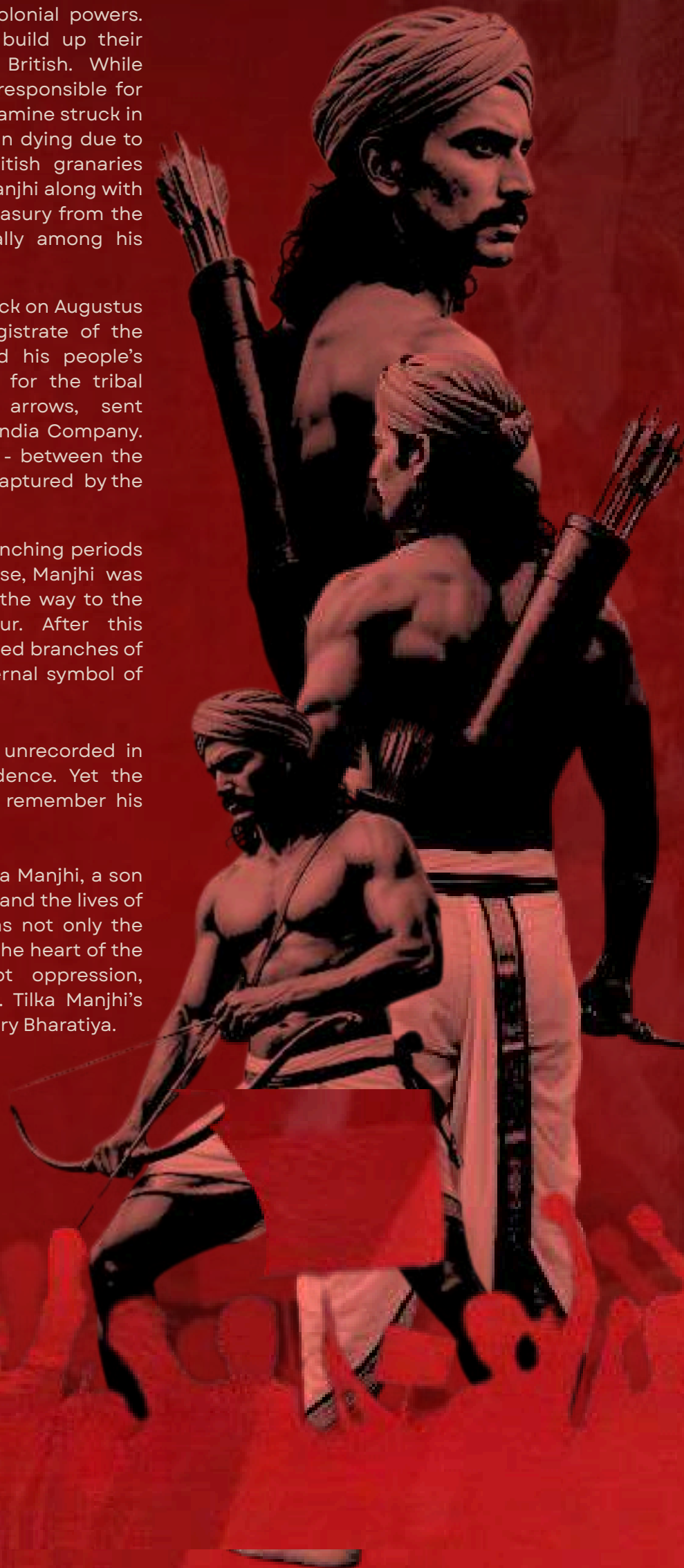
He helped his community understand how their forest could be used as a weapon against the British colonial powers. Manjhi created a place for his people to build up their courage and skills to fight against the British. While simultaneously creating a group of people responsible for the community's welfare. But then in 1770, a famine struck in the Santhal region of Bihar and people began dying due to starvation and lack of food. While the British granaries overflowed with food stocks. Knowing this, Manjhi along with his rebellious army looted the company's treasury from the granaries and distributed the wealth equally among his villagers.

Tilka's fiercest act, however, was his bold attack on Augustus Cleveland, a British administrator and magistrate of the Santhal region, the primary reason behind his people's suffering. This attack was a major victory for the tribal villagers, whose "primitive" bows and arrows, sent shockwaves through the entire British East India Company. After a long and furious to-and-fro struggle - between the colonials and Tilka - the lionheart was finally captured by the British in 1875.

What followed was one of the most heartwrenching periods of torture. Tied with ropes to the tails of a horse, Manjhi was dragged across the harsh, jagged roads all the way to the British Collector's Residence in Bhagalpur. After this torturous journey, he was hung from the gnarled branches of a banyan tree. This sacrifice became an eternal symbol of nationalism for the people of the region.

For decades his story went unnoticed and unrecorded in history books and the stories of independence. Yet the people of Bihar and Jharkhand continue to remember his resistance and sacrifice.

This Independence Day, let us remember Tilka Manjhi, a son of Bharat who fought for the dignity, the land and the lives of his people. He reminds us that freedom was not only the responsibility of kings and politicians, but in the heart of the forests where people refused to accept oppression, humiliation and suppression of their identity. Tilka Manjhi's sacrifice should serve as an inspiration for every Bharatiya.



THE DEVIL WEARS A Price Tag



Some fashion lunatic would have told you at least once to dress well, no matter the occasion. Well, if you'd listened, then you'd probably have ended up in big fashion houses, completely awestruck, after seeing the latest, trendiest clothes in huge volumes, yet completely unaware of their source. The repeating cycle of new trends and wardrobe upheavals has resulted in fast fashion, an industry which - shamelessly - lives up to its name. These clothes are produced in colossal volumes, simply to be dumped after a week or two once the "hype" is over. But the villainy of this industry doesn't end with just resource wastage, its roots go much deeper... For is it a coincidence that 50% of the workers employed (read: exploited) are women?

The devil embodies himself as the illegal Sumangali scheme, right here in Tamil Nadu. A scheme that stretches the boundaries of deception since it's just bonded labor with flamboyant marketing. 'Sumangali' literally translates to 'happily married woman' in Tamil. This scheme is majorly marketed to Dalit families in rural areas as a 'marriage assistance system' where recruiters go village to village and promise parents a hefty monetary sum in exchange for their daughters work in spinning and weaving mills for around 3 years. The victims are generally aged 14-18 years, and since in most rural communities, marriage is considered a financial burden, such a scheme is welcomed, despite its atrocity.

The recruiters strike the iron hot and sell it off as an opportunity for young girls to earn their marriage. And the naïve, uneducated fathers fall for it, thinking that they are relieved of future debt. The dowry relief amount given to the fathers, a meagre amount ranging anywhere from ₹30,000 for ₹70,000 for three whole years, is only paid if their daughters work three years without a single leave, even for health reasons. Fathers reap the "profits" as their daughters become near-slaves and are sold off in marriage.

Many incidents even report supervisors giving girls unlabeled 'painkillers' to keep them from taking time off. Foundational investigative reports like *Captured by Cotton*, published in 2011, and *Still Captured by Cotton*, published in 2012, bring out the real struggles faced by these women. Recruiters bring large numbers of girls and keep them confined in unnoticed guest houses or hostels which most of the time are leased for a time period as their stay over there is not confirmed for their time in servitude. They're shifted on an irregular basis, normally to jurisdictions with lenient labor laws or regions in which these racketeers have "old settings".



These cash-hungry, moral deviants discourage women from even taking bathroom breaks. They label their sewing unskilled and put them under the bracket of trainees to justify low wages. So low that they are actually counted as daily stipends, varying from Rs 40 to Rs 100. Tiruppur, Coimbatore, and Erode mills even report extending 12-hour shifts to 14 to 16 hours in exchange of a menial bonus.

Arisa and SOMO reported that these girls are fired in their 34th or 35th month without citations of a reason to not pay the final dowry aid amount, so all their hard work goes in vain. Nowadays, these frivolous schemes are tagged as “Marriage Benefit Funds” or “Social Security Schemes” and are advertised to gullible, uneducated parents. The main reason: women are seen as temporary workers, used to lower wages, and contractors assume that they're fine with the inhumane pay disparity, and are therefore given lesser or no job security at all.

Complex supply chains are also a major reason for this sad state of affairs. Brands not completely aware of or deliberately turning a blind eye to their unethical sourcing and production conditions are actually shown as shattered pieces of the whole truth. These brands, knowingly or unknowingly, run a scandal; they claim to endorse ‘Girl Power’ while keeping more than 60 million women working under poverty around the globe. Quite ironic, isn't it?

We as consumers play a bigger role. Our constant, insatiable desire for renewing our wardrobes at cheap rates put these fashion houses in a pickle: Unfortunately, the only way to make a t-shirt costing Rs. 599/- more profitable is by exploiting the person stitching it, which most often happens to be a helpless young girl.



FASCIST

-a political system based on a very powerful leader, state control, and being extremely proud of country and race, and in which political opposition is not allowed

[fa-shuhst]



CANVASSING

- mustering political support or establishing turf by visiting homes in a particular constituency.

[kan-vuhs-uhng]



MACHIAVELLIAN

- deploying cunning and deceitful tactics to hoard political power because the path doesn't matter only achieving the goal does.

[ma-kee-uh-veh-lee-uhn]



ORDINANCE

-some law or bill or act passed by cabinet only with president approval, no discussion or presentation in parliament.

[aw-duh-nuhns]



DEMAGOGUE

-a political leader who gains power by using emotional speeches, playing on people's fears and prejudices, and making false promises instead of using logical arguments and facts

[dem-uh-gog]



THE WAY BACK

VIRAJ LAL | IB I YEAR

*And Steve dug down.
Through the bars.
Through the long, dry hollow of wasted breath.
And found the thing that held him
more tenderly than death.*

*He went into the sweat,
the stones, the steam, the heavy weight of dark,
and learned to work the flint by hand,
a slow and wordless prayer
until the edge remembered his grip.
At dawn he burned the sage.
He let the cedar smoke unspool,
loosening, strand by strand, the knot that silence had
fastened behind his eyes. "I came back to my culture, and I
healed."*

*Now I watch you
at the edge of your own unwatered ground,
a name worn smooth as river stone
resting in a mouth that no longer knows its shape.
The scar on your palm has its own dialect
you stopped translating it
before you learned to read.
The story you wear was once a tongue
inside a grandfather's throat
now it sits in your chest like a splinter
you mistake for bone.*

*Steve Knockwood found the trail
inside a cage of cold and stone,
a box built to unmake a man,
to hollow out the marrow and the bone.
Some taught him how to speak the name he'd long since let
go,
the medicine his grandfather carried
before the shame began its slow, corrosive work.*

*For generations, they had tried to scour the old ways clean,
to make a people unlearn
the ancient grammar of their hands.
The language faded in the mouth.
The needle found the vein.
Until the children of the lost
forgot how to answer the wind.*

*But culture is a patient root
travelling deep beneath the scars.
It waits for its sons, digging through the dark,
until they strike the living thing
that has always known their name.*



*Somewhere a grandfather's flint
still waits under glass in a museum.*

*Somewhere a ceremony breathes
in the lungs of an elder
who has not spoken it aloud
since the year the language went underground.*

*You don't need a cell to lose the heft of your own hands.
The small, daily removals:
the untaught prayer,
the festival you step past like a stranger at the gate,
the elder's tale you turn away
because it sounds too much like grief.
They don't scar.
They sit.
They settle in the places where your name once stood
until you no longer know you carried one.*

*But beneath the noise of the living,
beneath the dry reed splitting in the wind,
there is a ceremony that never stopped waiting,
older than your oldest need.
It doesn't ask how long you've strayed.
It only recognizes the shape of you:
the way your rivers still remember their cut.*

*Your culture does not punish you for wandering. It only
holds the door open
with the same hands that first taught you to kneel.
And when you finally walk back to the water where your
elders prayed,
you will not need to speak.*

*The river remembers what the mouth cannot say. The root
still knows the taste of stolen ground. And somewhere
inside the dark,
the flint still dreams of the hand
that has not yet returned.*



Captures @CIRS

Prayer brings together things which, of course, were never apart at any time.



To the Juniors.



Trivia sparks minds.



Rhythm heals.

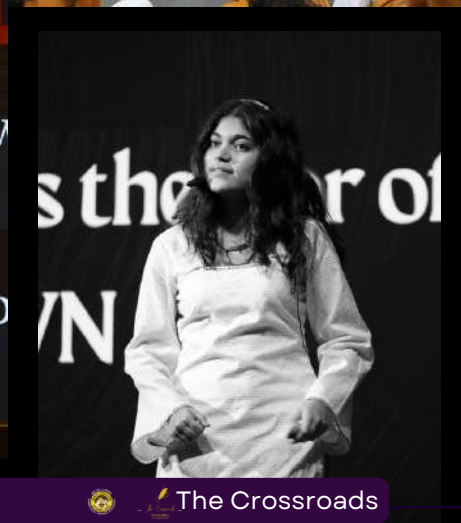




Here's to a new beginning – where every step brings new possibilities.



इयव्वर इह इव्वरुव्वल



CREATIVE CORNER



Trisha V ~ VII 🌟



Tarushi Agarwal - XII 🌟



Kabir Kedia - VII 🌟



Anaira Bhageria ~ VI 🌟



Vedant A ~ VIII 🌟



Radhya Kedia ~ IX 🌟



CLASSIFIEDS



Living In Awareness in Duties | August 2026

'Living in Awareness in Duties' means recognizing our role in the present moment. Whether as a student, a teacher, or a friend, awareness allows us to perform our actions with 100% focus and a spirit of dedication (Ishwara Arpana Buddhi). When we are aware of our duties, we don't need supervision; our own intellect becomes our guide.

THE CROSSROADS

Facilitator:

Br. Sanatan
Chaitanya

Editor:

K. Nishanth Reddy

Assisting Editor:

Rhea Sontakke

Sub-Editor:

Arnav Nair

Director of Events:

Tanmay Khakharia

Director of Design:

Shaurya Gadhyan

Assisting Designers:

Arnav Saraf
Ritika Deorah

**Director of
Photography:**

Radha Goyal

**Social Media
Correspondent:**

Naitik Agarwala

**Special
Correspondent:**

Avika Rahul Mundra

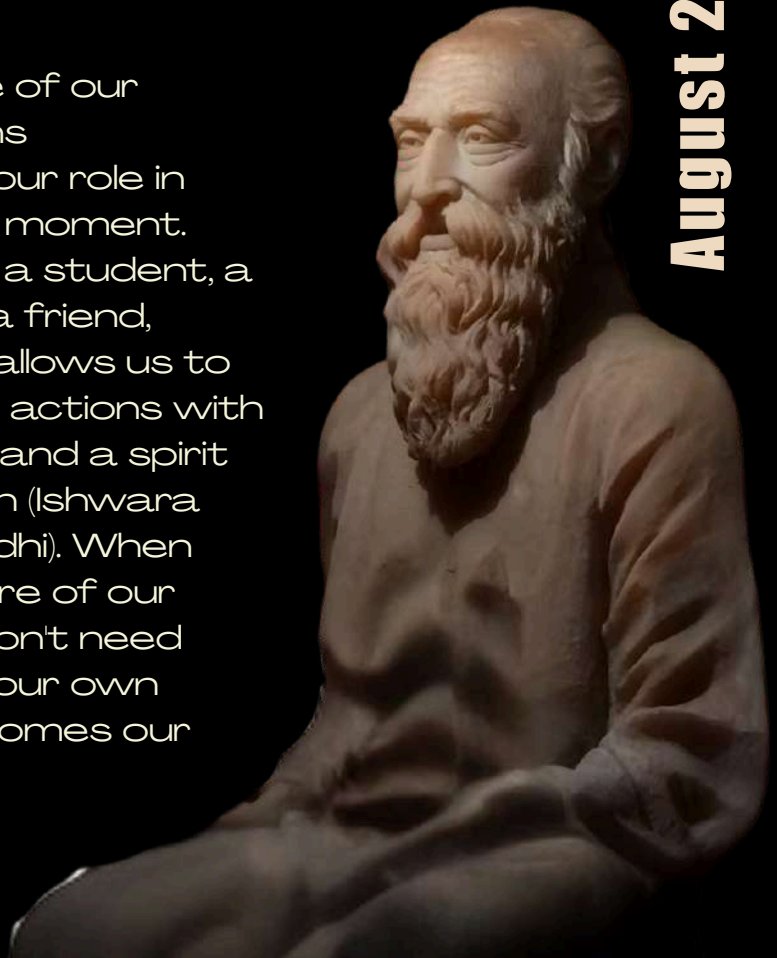
**Junior
Correspondent :**

S. Rithesh

DHARMA *Awareness in Duties* DUTIES

August 2026

Being aware of our duties means recognizing our role in the present moment. Whether as a student, a teacher, or a friend, awareness allows us to perform our actions with 100% focus and a spirit of dedication (Ishwara Arpana Buddhi). When we are aware of our duties, we don't need supervision; our own intellect becomes our guide.



Our gratitude to the CIRS management for giving flight to our initiative.

Chinmaya International Residential School

Swami Chinmayananda Lane, Nallur Vayal Post, Siruvani Main Road
Coimbatore - 641114, Tamil Nadu, India

The Crossroads follows the standards of American English.